‘Um. Where would you like to go?’

We pulled out into the road, neither of us having a clue where we were heading but both of us sure we wanted to go there together. I knew her manager, Simon, was really nervous about the Girls and their boys. Anything that was going on in Spiceworld was all over the papers almost before it had happened in those days. I didn’t want to be sharing her company with anybody anyway, to be honest. So we drove around looking for somewhere that would be private enough.

The other reason for wanting to be out of the way was that she had a boyfriend, Stuart, who she was still seeing. He was off skiing in France with her dad at the time. Victoria was straight with me about it from the start; like me, she tries to be completely honest with people. We’d only just met. She didn’t want us to mess up each other’s lives, or anyone else’s for that matter. There was just one difficult moment and that was that night: Stuart called Victoria on her cell phone while we were driving around together. I was single, of course, but I told Victoria all about the important girlfriends in my past: Deana, who I’d been with for three years when I first moved up to Manchester and who had been so important to me as a teenager away from home for the first time; and Helen, who I’d been seeing for eighteen months more recently and who’d stepped away when people started fussing about this young lad from London making a name for himself at United.

Victoria told me about Stuart, and about a lot else besides, as we drove past crowded pub after crowded pub around North-east London. When you meet The One, there’s a lot of catching up to do. We made a good start that night and, an hour or so later, I had my good idea:

‘I know this little Chinese.’

There was a restaurant in Chingford that I’d visited with Mum and Dad. Nothing spectacular but it had one big thing to recommend it: there was never anyone else in the place whenever I’d eaten there. I gave Victoria directions; we parked and went in. Perfect: it was absolutely deserted. We sat down and I ordered:

‘Could we have a Coke and a Diet Coke, please?’

The lady who ran the restaurant looked at us. *Oh, the last of the big spenders*. She didn’t have a clue who we were. I could understand her not recognizing me, but Victoria? It was a little world of its own, that Chinese.